

Chapter 21_1 - Beauty

"Master, this..." Qiu Yi hurriedly bent down to pick them up, but was stopped by Chu Qingqiu's outstretched hand, who said it was fine.

Then, Chu Qingqiu opened her palm, and those beast stones floated up again, returning to her hand. However, when she put them back into the pouch, her movements were no longer as gentle as before.

After a while, Chu Qingqiu suddenly placed the pouch heavily on the table and said in a low voice: "Qiu Yi, where is that Ruyan Tower?"

While undercurrents were surging there, here was a turbulent storm. Rong Jin had already agreed to listen to her detailed account and dragged the woman out of the inn, but the woman still hadn't stopped crying. She cried all the way down the street, making the pedestrians on the street turn their heads one after another.

Finally, Ning Fuyi could no longer bear it. She grabbed a butcher's knife from the roadside and thrust it into the ground, burying half the blade, which finally stopped the woman's crying.

The woman fearfully covered her mouth, only tears still flowing.

"Fuyi!" Rong Jin was kind-hearted and couldn't bear to see this. He immediately scolded Ning Fuyi, then pulled out the gleaming knife and returned it with an apologetic smile.

"If you truly want to save your daughter, then be quiet and explain the whole story clearly. Crying and wailing like this will only make your daughter die more thoroughly!" Ning Fuyi said irritably, wiping off the grease that had gotten on her palm.

Seeing that Ning Fuyi had frightened the woman, Liu Wenzhu quickly turned to block her fierce gaze and gently comforted the woman: "Aunt, look, we're all going to Ruyan Tower. If you still don't explain things clearly and only say you want to save someone, how can we help you?"

After being gently comforted by Liu Wenzhu, the woman's emotions finally calmed down somewhat. She took two deep breaths and stammered out the whole story.

It turned out this woman was an ordinary citizen of this town. Her husband had died early, leaving only her and her daughter to make a living selling tea leaves. Her daughter had been beautiful since childhood and was often harassed by some local thugs, but fortunately the daughter was clever and could escape each time.

The woman was getting old, and an old back injury from her youth made it difficult for her to carry heavy loads. Her daughter voluntarily took over her work, carrying poles to the street every morning to sell tea leaves, then returning home in the evening.

"But, but yesterday..." The woman looked like she was about to cry again, but didn't dare to. She only covered her nose and sobbed a few times. "I waited from day to night, then from night to dawn, but never saw her figure. Finally, being too anxious, I came out to inquire. I asked all along the long street, and only then did someone tell me that she was kidnapped by those people from Ruyan Tower."

"In broad daylight, is there no law!" Rong Jin was so angry his face turned red to his neck. "I'll go rescue your daughter right now!"

As soon as he finished speaking, Ning Fuyi quickly and agilely stopped him, saying in a low voice: "Senior brother, wait. Setting aside whether this person's words are true, just talking about that Ruyan Tower - if they really have such audacity to snatch people in the street, it proves their background is definitely not small. If we rashly go charging in, not only will we alert them, but if we're no match for them, we'll hurt ourselves."

"But..." Rong Jin turned around.

"This servant is just a mortal woman. I can only beg you immortal masters. Not a single word of what this servant says is false! Please save my daughter. Your great kindness, this servant would repay with her life!" Seeing the woman about to kneel again, Rong Jin hurriedly grabbed her arm and looked at Ning Fuyi with unbearable feelings.

"This matter is of great importance. I suggest we first find Elder Yuanming and then decide." Ning Fuyi had developed a heart of stone in her previous life. Now looking at the woman, she only felt annoyed. After speaking, she was about to walk back.

"But Elder Yuanming went to Tongchuan early this morning to search for yesterday's demonic beast after treating you. By the time we find the elder, the person will long be dead somewhere." Liu Wenzhu also said with difficulty. Like Rong Jin, she had always been soft-hearted. Now seeing common people in trouble, she naturally couldn't sit by and watch.

But Ning Fuyi wasn't like that. Her heart was very hard.

"Then let's go find Chu..." Her words got stuck halfway in her throat. Setting aside that Chu Qingqiu was still injured yesterday, even if Chu Qingqiu was completely unharmed, she didn't want to swallow her pride and ask Chu Qingqiu for help.

Seeing that she wouldn't agree, the woman cried heartbrokenly. She no longer begged them, but sat down on the ground and wailed to the sky.

"Man'er¹, it's mother's fault for being useless, mother can't save you. A child is a mother's life. If you die now, mother will definitely accompany you, definitely won't let you go alone!" Saying this, she was about to crash into a nearby pillar.

"Enough!" Ning Fuyi couldn't bear it anymore and shouted sternly. It felt like a thorn had been stuck in her heart, causing hidden pain.

It wasn't anything else, but the mother's words that suddenly reminded her of Ning Changfeng, making her heart feel uncomfortable.

Moreover, she knew Rong Jin and Liu Wenzhu's personalities. No matter how much she opposed it, neither of them could be so heartless.

She took a deep breath and turned around: "What does your daughter look like? Do you have a portrait?"

"No, no. We're poor people, how could we have portraits?" The woman wiped her tears and said, "I only know she's pretty, with a birthmark on her forehead, a flower-shaped birthmark."

A flower-shaped birthmark? A strange feeling flashed through Ning Fuyi's mind, but she didn't think about it carefully for the moment. Instead, she said: "Senior brother, Wenzhu, let's find a quiet place to discuss this first."

The so-called Ruyan Tower was located at the easternmost part of the town. The location wasn't particularly good, and very few people entered. If it weren't for the notice pasted on the main gate with today's featured courtesan's name, Ning Fuyi would have thought it was an empty building.

Its appearance was also very peculiar - a seven-story octagonal tower with red walls and black tiles, standing straight up to the sky. It was completely out of place with the town's simple atmosphere, as if someone had forcibly placed it in the middle of the road.

"I inquired about it earlier. This used to be empty land. Ruyan Tower only appeared last year. It appeared silently, with no one knowing who its owner is or who manages it. So some people say it's a ghost tower. Ordinary people don't dare come here - only outsiders passing through occasionally go in." Liu Wenzhu said softly after returning to their private room. When she said this, her face was somewhat pale with fright.

"We cultivators practice the way of the Six Realms of Reincarnation. What ghosts are we afraid of?" Rong Jin poured her a cup of hot tea to comfort her. "Right, Fuyi?"

Ning Fuyi hummed in agreement. Her gaze looked through the window toward the octagonal tower across the way. Standing under the blue sky and white clouds, it indeed looked eerie. No wonder Liu Wenzhu felt fear.

"So what should we do?" Liu Wenzhu asked.

Without waiting for Rong Jin to answer, Ning Fuyi spoke: "Senior brother, you stay here to watch over that woman, then use the transmission token to contact Elder Yuanming as soon as possible. Wenzhu and I will sneak in to investigate the situation."

"How can this be allowed!" Rong Jin immediately objected. "You two don't have high cultivation, and you're both young girls. How can you enter that kind of place?"

"Precisely because Wenzhu and I don't have high cultivation, you need to stay outside. If something happens to us, you can provide support. If you go in and we stay, then if there's an accident, we won't even have the strength to fly for reinforcements." Ning Fuyi tapped the table with her hand.

Rong Jin was momentarily speechless. He and Liu Wenzhu looked at each other.

This Ning Fuyi was clearly still a young girl, so why did she speak like a composed elder?

"Alright." Rong Jin reluctantly agreed, then repeatedly instructed: "You must carry your transmission tokens with you. If anything seems wrong, notify me immediately. Also, if you still have no news by You hour², I'll immediately go save you."

"Don't worry." Ning Fuyi said, then stood up and cast an illusion technique, transforming herself into a male form.

Her features didn't change much, only her brow bone became higher, and the proportions of her facial features changed. Combined with her seductive phoenix eyes, she looked exactly like a young master from a noble family out for training.

Liu Wenzhu also followed suit. Her male form looked much more delicate, just like a pale-faced scholar going to take the imperial examination.

The two bid farewell to Rong Jin and, pretending to be visiting Furong Town for the first time, walked laughingly toward Ruyan Tower.

The closer they got to that towering octagonal tower, the stronger the eerie feeling in their hearts became. Ning Fuyi looked up at the windows upstairs - not a single one was open. It didn't look like any pleasure house; it looked more like a tomb.

She suppressed the feeling rising in her heart and stepped onto the stairs as usual. Suddenly, footsteps came from behind. She alertly turned to look, and when she saw the person's features clearly, she was immediately shocked.

"Chu..." Ning Fuyi's words stopped halfway and she swallowed them with difficulty.

How could Chu Qingqiu appear here? And dressed in men's clothing, having changed her appearance like them. She wore a plain white brocade robe with ornamental pendants jingling at her waist and an exquisitely carved jade crown on her head. Standing beside her in black clothes, Ning Fuyi looked like a servant.

With her long hair pulled up, her face was also exceptionally outstanding. Her eyebrows were high and arched, her peach blossom eyes naturally contained emotion, her lips were slightly pale but appeared even more pure - beautiful beyond gender distinction.

Ning Fuyi stood there in a daze until she heard Chu Qingqiu speak: "What are you standing there for? Go in."

With that, she carried her white jade flute in her hand and walked through the threshold with her hands behind her back, brushing past Ning Fuyi.

Seeing this, Liu Wenzhu beside her quickly poked Ning Fuyi's waist. Only then did Ning Fuyi come to her senses, coughed lightly to cover her surprise, and followed Chu Qingqiu's steps.

Although she didn't know why Chu Qingqiu had suddenly appeared, at least with her here, she felt somewhat more at ease.

The three walked silently through the dim entrance hall one after another. Fresh flower petals were scattered on the ground, and the faint sound of a pipa³ came from within the building, like flowing water over high mountains, trickling melodiously.

Footnotes:

1. **Man'er (曼儿)** - A feminine given name meaning "graceful"
2. **You hour (酉时)** - The traditional Chinese time period from 5:00 PM to 7:00 PM
3. **Pipa (琵琶)** - A traditional Chinese four-stringed musical instrument, often called the Chinese lute

Author's Notes: The story continues from previous chapters where Ning Fuyi, Rong Jin, and Liu Wenzhu are helping a distraught mother find her missing daughter who has allegedly been kidnapped by the mysterious Ruyan Tower.